



from a relative. More commonly, they are considered to have been chosen by the spirits themselves, the marker of which may be an unusual physical trait or a period of mental suffering. The chosen person then spends a lifetime studying their calling.

Trance-inducing ritual

In order to communicate with the spirit world, a shaman or other specialist often goes into a trance deliberately induced by ritual. The exact nature of the rites varies: in Mongolia, for instance, the

shaman may wear a crown of feathers or antlers, and sometimes fur, becoming variously a bird, a reindeer, or a bear to reinforce his or her spiritual transformation. In Mongolia and some other cultures, ceremonial observances are group activities. Members of the group may join in with chanting, song, drumming, or music. Fire, too, may be used to enhance the atmosphere and bring participants together. In parts of North and South America, psychoactive plants are ingested to help enter a trance or see visions.

▲ Modern-day shaman

In ritual dress, this Mongolian shaman plays a mouth harp and beats a drum in a fire ritual to mark the summer solstice. There are about 10,000 shamans in Mongolia. Male shamans are known as *böö*; female shamans are called *udgan*.